

Gillman Barracks & Forest Agency-Residents Meeting
1 September 2026, 8.49pm- 10.21pm, Fruit Room, Hort Park

Attendees: Rachel Ong, ~20 representatives from across HDB, URA, MND and NParks, and 25-30 residents from Telok Blangah, Depot Road, Preston Road and Pasir Panjang East

Background

Following the first [Get-Together on Gillman Barracks](#) held on 30 July at Telok Blangah CC, residents in the Gillman-surrounding area, upon prompts to find alternative uses for the site, continued working on [A Better Plan for Gillman](#).

On 18 August 2026, Gillman-surrounding residents had written to HDB, URA and NParks, calling for a resident-agency working dialogue, expressing concern about the short timeframe mentioned in MoS Alvin Tan's [doorstop interview](#) on 14 August 2026. The agencies did not respond directly.

Following multiple follow-up requests by residents, on 27 August, MP Rachel Ong confirmed over the phone with residents that MND was willing to engage at 8.30pm after the 6.30-8.30pm follow-up engagement titled "Building a Shared Future at Sunset Way & Gillman Barracks" session on 1 September 2026. For the FGD, residents understand that this engagement session included residents, academics, practitioners, interest groups, policymakers, students, and other concerned members of the public (see Annex for poster). The focus of the 29 August session was on Sunset Way, while 1 September session on Gillman Barracks.

On 28 August 2026, ahead of the 1 September 8.30-10pm meeting, residents had sent the Better Plan document and consolidated the names of those interested and submitted them to HDB, and MP Rachel Ong. On 31 August 2026, residents submitted the most updated residents list, and [A Better Plan for Gillman deck](#), which residents put together to present at the meeting. One Telok Blangah resident, DH, presented on residents' behalf.

Use of this document

This document is intended to serve as a factual, resident-generated record of the 1 September 2026 agencies-resident meeting. It has been compiled from contemporaneous notes taken by residents who attended the meeting. It may be used to:

- Inform residents who were unable to attend, particularly those living around Gillman Barracks and Forest, about the issues raised, responses provided by agencies, and matters that remained unresolved at the end of the meeting.
- Provide a reference for others interested in the future of Gillman Barracks and Forest, including members of the public, researchers, nature and heritage groups, and others following Singapore's planning and public-engagement processes.
- Preserve a contemporaneous record of the discussion, including questions and concerns raised by residents, statements made by agency representatives, areas of agreement and disagreement, and any follow-up actions or commitments discussed.

- Enable comparison with subsequent official accounts of the engagement, including government summaries, public statements and revised planning proposals. The record may help residents and others assess whether these accounts reflect the range and strength of views expressed at the meeting, and identify any points that may require clarification or correction.
- Support constructive follow-up with the agencies and MP, particularly on questions that could not be answered at the meeting, information requested by residents, the consideration of [A Better Plan for Gillman](#), and the form and timing of further engagement.

Note on the record: This is not an official transcript or verbatim record. It has been compiled from residents' verbatim notes and immediate recollections and is intended to capture the substance of the discussion as accurately and fairly as possible. Residents who attended the meeting are welcome to suggest factual corrections or additions.

Introduction and presentation on *A Better Plan for Gillman*

Introduction by Rachel Ong, MP for Telok Blangah welcoming all to this meeting. The time was quickly handed over to Telok Blangah resident DH to present A Better Plan for Gillman.

Telok Blangah resident DH presented [A Better Plan for Gillman deck](#).

Discussion and responses to *A Better Plan for Gillman*

HDB described the proposal as “well put together” and said it did not know whether something similar had “been done before in the history of Singapore”. An HDB representative described the residents’ initiative as encouraging, although it “makes our work harder”. A resident responded: “It could be easier. We are here to work with you.”

HDB explained that government planning takes a broad, island-wide view and that potential development sites are already considered within this wider planning process. In response to the additional Alexandra Park site identified by residents, HDB said that the area was already planned for future housing, which affected a significant part of the alternative proposed in the Better Plan. HDB was unable to provide the eventual housing demand or yield for Gillman at the meeting.

Retaining 100% of Gillman Forest

The strongest and most consistently expressed request from residents was for the Government to test whether the whole of Gillman Forest could be retained while still providing housing.

HDB stated several times that “100% is really not feasible”, although it said planning teams were actively looking at how to increase the amount of greenery and forest retained compared with the earlier proposal. HDB also asked residents, if some forest had to be cleared, which part they would be prepared to give up.

Residents resisted framing the decision as a binary choice between forest and housing. One resident said:

“You are putting us in a binary — it’s not forest or housing. You want City in Nature. Erasing forest for housing is against that narrative.”

Residents instead asked agencies to expand the geographical and policy parameters within which the housing requirement was being considered. Suggestions included increasing density on already developed land, bringing forward other planned housing sites, reconsidering the sequencing of development, and testing whether housing could be concentrated around the MRT and existing built-up areas while leaving the forest intact.

Another resident explained why residents continued to ask for complete retention:

“Why do we want 100%? Because you guys keep giving us blank answers.”

Residents said they did not have sufficient information about the housing yield, constraints or alternatives to make an informed judgement about how much forest should be sacrificed. They also stressed that landscaped green space should not automatically be treated as equivalent to an existing forest.

Later in the discussion, the call became still more explicit. Residents urged agencies to begin with the planning premise that “the forest cannot be touched” and then design around that constraint. One resident described Gillman as a “jewel” that could not be replaced, while another said:

“Keep it. Design around it. Landscape, architecture. Make this a jewel.”

Another summed up the requested change in approach as: “Change the calculus.”

Residents called for a different approach to planning

A recurring theme was that residents did not simply want a different outcome at Gillman; they wanted agencies to reconsider how decisions involving remaining forests are made.

Residents questioned why Singapore should wait for future planning and construction innovations before changing its approach to forests. One asked: “If you can be so creative 10 years from now with SERS/VERS etc, why not do it now?” Others urged the government to “think creatively”, move away from business-as-usual approaches, and account more seriously for climate change and urban heat.

One resident described the repeated conflict over individual forests as evidence of a wider problem:

“We are doing the same things over and over. Is there a way to change the way we do things?”

Residents asked whether changing climate conditions, urban heat, new technologies and changing demographic assumptions warranted revisiting earlier planning assumptions rather than treating them as fixed. One urged the government to “take a pause and question yourselves to look at things differently”, stressing that reconsideration would not necessarily be perceived as backtracking.

Residents also raised the timing of environmental assessment and public participation. Several felt that by the time the EIA was released and residents were invited to comment, important choices had already narrowed. One resident said there needed to be “enough runway” for engagement before reaching this stage, rather than appearing merely to “tick the boxes by doing the EIA”.

HDB and NParks on how planning and environmental assessment work

HDB acknowledged that the Government was continuing to learn and evolve in how it engages the public. An HDB representative observed that EIAs were relatively new to the planning process and said that previously the approach had broadly been to conduct an EIA, publish it, receive responses and proceed. Gillman and Sunset Way had been different, and the government would continue evolving the way it engaged and incorporated feedback.

NParks explained that EIAs are not generally undertaken at the island-wide master-planning stage. Planning begins at a broad scale and becomes progressively more detailed. NParks participates as a technical agency, providing biodiversity information and assessments to inform the wider planning process alongside other agencies. URA ultimately has to balance multiple competing needs.

NParks also cautioned against the perception that sites are considered independently or parcel by parcel. It said URA and other agencies plan at town, regional and island-wide scales, taking account of different land uses and time horizons. NParks nevertheless acknowledged that agencies “could do better engaging the public” around this broader planning context.

URA on alternative sites and density

Residents repeatedly asked why housing could not be accommodated through different densities or at other sites, particularly already urbanised areas.

URA explained that density decisions are site-specific. Factors include proximity to transport nodes and height constraints. Areas well served by transport may support greater density, while constraints such as flight paths can limit development elsewhere.

Residents nevertheless felt they lacked sufficient visibility of the criteria being applied. One described the process as a “black box”, asking why lower density might be planned elsewhere while an ecologically significant site near Gillman was being considered for development.

When a resident asked what would have to be given up in order to keep Gillman Forest, HDB responded in substance that “if we don’t build here, you have to build somewhere else.” Residents

then asked precisely where that would be, who would be affected and why particular communities or sites were selected to bear those impacts.

Alternative housing and policy options proposed by residents

Residents proposed a number of ways in which the underlying housing requirement could be reconsidered rather than beginning from the assumption that part of Gillman Forest must be developed. These included:

- increasing density on existing built-up areas in Telok Blangah where technically feasible;
- building first on already urbanised or industrial land, including the Depot Road/Telok Blangah Street 31 area;
- bringing forward housing already planned elsewhere and pushing development of Gillman further into the future;
- building part of the required housing near Labrador MRT while adjusting the timing of other housing projects to maintain the overall housing pipeline;
- examining whether demographic and housing-demand assumptions should be revisited in light of changing population, climate and social conditions; and
- considering demand-side housing policies, including whether incentives could make it easier for older residents occupying larger flats to downsize voluntarily, thereby making more existing housing stock available.

One resident asked whether Singapore had “exhausted all the policies and avenues” before concluding that additional forest land needed to be developed. The recurring request was to “change the calculus”, rather than treating the existing planning parameters as immutable.

How should the value of the forest enter planning?

Residents also asked how existing forest is valued when the government compares different land uses. One resident asked:

“How much decision making is a financial one? We know so little as to why you choose to build on forest instead of brownfield? Is it the same value to you in your parameters? For example, one sqm of carpark land vs. one sqm of forested land, how is it valued?”

In response to the question about whether financial value affected the decision to develop forest rather than brownfield land, HDB said that it did not take the matter into consideration in the way the resident had framed it, and that land value was more location-based. This prompted residents to ask more directly how the forest itself factors into planning decisions and whether its intangible benefits are adequately recognised.

Residents highlighted biodiversity, ecological connectivity, recreation, wellbeing and particularly urban cooling. Several described their experience of increasing heat as making the issue personally salient and questioned how urban-heat benefits are incorporated into planning assessments.

On urban heat and cooling, residents raised an important point about 300 [cooling centres](#) now having to be established to shield people from higher temperatures ahead. Residents said that clearing the forest that provides cooling as an ecosystem service while simultaneously announcing the cooling centres makes the government appear “foolish”. One resident shared that people are genuinely feeling the impact of climate change, and that the government should stop defending the removal of the forest.

Agency response to the non-housing elements of the Better Plan

Agency representatives were more receptive to several elements of the Better Plan beyond its proposed land-use configuration.

HDB said that ideas including repurposing existing buildings, mixed-use and multi-storey facilities, sports uses and better connectivity were workable. It also indicated that the revised concept would retain more greenery than the earlier proposal.

NParks responded positively to ideas including the stream boardwalk and forest/nature trails. NParks said it was “prepared to study” these proposals, while noting that their exact location and design would have to account for impacts on trees and soil conditions.

Residents also proposed bringing STB and other relevant agencies into subsequent discussions. They argued that Gillman could become a distinctive nature, heritage, wellness and tourism destination connecting Kent Ridge, Bukit Chandu, HortPark, Gillman, Telok Blangah Hill, Mount Faber, Brani and Sentosa. Gillman was described as one of the “pearls” along this wider landscape and as a potentially important node between the Southern Ridges and the coast.

What remained unresolved

Towards the end of the meeting, residents repeatedly asked what would happen next and whether the Better Plan would actually influence the revised concept.

HDB said it would take the proposals back, consider what form further engagement could take, and work on **strengthening east-west connectivity, minimising forest loss if forest had to be removed, and retaining a sizeable forest area**. It also described revitalising Gillman Barracks with the appropriate agencies as a good suggestion. However, HDB said it was not able at that point to provide the answers residents were seeking.

Residents specifically asked for a subsequent meeting at which agencies could provide the projected housing yield and, if appropriate, a response or counter-proposal to the Better Plan:

“We are not experts... We are calling on you, domain experts, to help us develop this plan to be something buildable.”

HDB indicated that feedback from this and other engagements would need to be processed and the concept reworked, with a summary findings report expected in approximately a month. It

suggested that the housing yield might be clearer by then, but no firm deadline or detailed timetable for the next stage of resident engagement was provided.

MP Rachel Ong closed the meeting by expressing the hope that agencies had heard residents' appeal: **to preserve the forest while still being able to build homes**. She also expressed the hope that the next stage would involve residents engaging with the plans rather than learning about them through the media, and recognised the considerable time residents had invested in conceptualising the Better Plan.

Overview of resident interventions

Residents made approximately 69 separate interventions during the discussion, comprising questions, proposals, responses to agency representatives and requests for follow-up. Many interventions covered more than one issue. A thematic review of the notes indicates that the most recurrent themes concerned retaining Gillman Forest, greater transparency about the basis for planning decisions, reconsideration of the existing planning approach, alternative housing configurations and sequencing, and meaningful resident participation. Calls to retain the whole forest were made repeatedly throughout the meeting and were often accompanied by proposals for how housing needs might instead be accommodated through different densities, sites, sequencing or policy approaches. Residents therefore did not generally frame their position as opposition to housing. Rather, they repeatedly asked agencies to test whether Singapore's housing objectives could be met without clearing Gillman Forest, and to explain the evidence and constraints if the government concluded that this was not possible.

Analysis

The above notes show that the discussion had three dominant and interconnected messages:

1. Retain the whole of Gillman Forest, and require a clear explanation if the government considers this impossible.
2. Do not frame the issue as a binary choice between housing and forest; test alternative sites, densities, sequencing and policies.
3. Change the planning process so that residents have the information and opportunity to consider alternatives before the fundamental choices have effectively been narrowed.

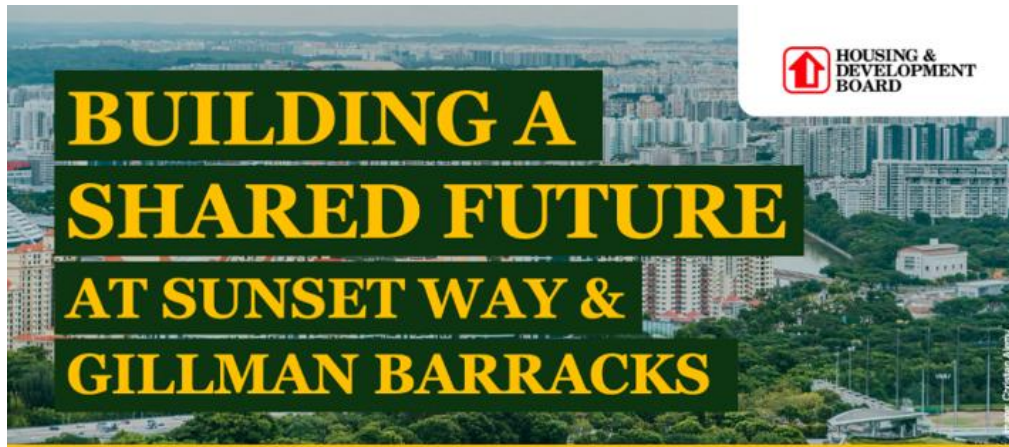
Thematic coding of resident interventions

Theme	Approx. resident interventions	What residents were saying

Retain Gillman Forest / minimise forest loss	25	Repeated calls to retain the whole forest; reject assumption that some forest necessarily has to go; distinguish forest from landscaped greenery; design development around existing forest.
Transparency, information & basis for decisions	21	Requests for housing yield, assumptions, constraints, decision criteria, who makes the final decision, why alternatives cannot work, and more information so residents can meaningfully evaluate choices.
Change the planning approach / “change the calculus”	20	Calls to move beyond business-as-usual, rethink sequencing and assumptions, consider forests earlier in planning, innovate now rather than later, and avoid repeatedly confronting communities with forest-versus-development choices.
Alternative housing configurations, sites & sequencing	17	Higher density on built-up land, Alexandra Park, Depot Road/industrial sites, building near MRT first, bringing other housing forward, delaying Gillman, expanding the planning area rather than treating Gillman in isolation.
Meaningful engagement / participation	16	Residents wanting to work with agencies, engage before choices narrow, know what remains open, speak to decision-makers, have further working sessions, and receive an agency response/counterproposal.
Better Plan – consideration and implementation	14	Requests that agencies actually assess the Better Plan, help residents make it technically buildable, respond to its proposals, and involve other relevant agencies.
Climate change, urban heat & ecological value	12	Urban cooling, climate adaptation, changing climate conditions, forest ecosystem benefits and questioning whether these values are adequately incorporated into planning.

EIA / timing and environmental assessment	9	Questions about when EIA enters planning, whether it came too late, adequacy of the baseline/study, possibility of an addendum, and whether environmental information can influence fundamental choices rather than only mitigation.
Heritage, tourism, recreation & connectivity	10	Gillman as a destination; Southern Ridges/coast connection; tourism; heritage buildings; trails; forest experience; STB involvement; preserving ecological/recreational connectivity.
Equity / distribution of development impacts	7	Who bears the costs of development, public versus private/landed areas, why particular communities are affected, and whether burdens are being shared fairly.
Housing-demand and wider policy alternatives	4	Questions about underlying housing/population assumptions and whether policies such as facilitating downsizing could reduce pressure for additional construction.

Annex



We have received a range of views and suggestions, which have helped us better understand what matters to Singaporeans and the different perspectives surrounding the future of these places.

As we refine plans for Sunset Way and Gillman Barracks, we want to build on what we have heard and work together to navigate different priorities and trade-offs.

Session Details

Date: Tuesday, 1 September 2026

Time: 6:30 PM – 8:30 PM

Venue: Hort Park, Multi-Purpose Hall

*Registration starts at 6 PM

Register Here:

Reply to hdbconnects@hdb.gov.sg by **27 August 2026** along with your name and contact number.

Note: this was the official engagement organized by HDB. The agencies-resident meeting captured above was specifically requested by residents.